

Against 'Framelessness' in Environmental Aesthetics

Abstract Wordcount: 217

Essay Wordcount: 3211

Abstract:

Environmental aestheticians, from Hepburn to Carlson, routinely deploy a distinction between 'framed' and 'frameless' objects of aesthetic experience, associating framelessness with nature and using this association to justify separate methodological approaches to natural and non-natural aesthetics. This paper argues that the framed/frameless distinction should be abandoned entirely.

The central argument is simple but general: to aesthetically appreciate something is necessarily to single it out as distinct from everything else, and in doing so to draw a boundary around it. Any object of aesthetic appreciation is therefore necessarily framed. 'Framelessness' is not a property that any object of aesthetic appreciation can possess.

This conclusion is tested against the most intuitively compelling candidates for framelessness. Storms, landscapes, and vast natural expanses are shown to be framed on any plausible conception of boundaries, whether objective or subject-dependent. Nature-as-a-whole, the most resistant case, is shown to be either framed or not genuinely aesthetically appreciable: if finite, it is framed as any other object; if infinite, it cannot be the object of aesthetic appreciation at all.

The dissolution of the framed/frameless distinction undermines the 'Twin Distinction' between natural and non-natural aesthetics that depends on it. Environmental aestheticians should abandon framelessness as a theoretical category, and with it the justification for treating natural and non-natural objects of appreciation as methodologically distinct.

Introduction

Environmental aesthetics has long sought to characterise what is distinctive about the aesthetic appreciation of nature. A central axis of this project is the claim that natural objects, unlike artworks, are ‘frameless’—lacking the boundaries that define and delimit what is and is not part of an artwork. This alleged framelessness has been used to justify methodologically distinct approaches to natural and non-natural aesthetics: if nature has no frame, it cannot be appreciated in the way a framed artwork can. This paper argues that the framed/frameless distinction rests on a concept—‘framelessness’—that is inapplicable to anything that can be aesthetically appreciated at all. As such, I argue that ‘the framed/frameless distinction’ (FFD henceforth) and its supposed relation to the non-natural/natural distinction should be abandoned, and that we should not consider it a justification to approach natural aesthetics and non-natural aesthetics differently.

I begin by defining the focus of this paper, ‘framelessness’ as it is used by contemporary environmental aestheticians (§1). I then establish the general claim: the concept of ‘framelessness’ cannot apply to anything that can be aesthetically experienced at all, because directed aesthetic appreciation necessarily has an individuated object (§2). This conclusion is then tested against the most popular and intuitive candidates for ‘frameless’ objects of aesthetic appreciation—storms, landscapes, etc.—showing that each is framed on any plausible account of boundaries (§3). Finally, I address the most difficult case: ‘nature-as-a-whole’ (§4). I demonstrate that it is *either* framed *or* not genuinely aesthetically appreciable. Ultimately, this leads to the conclusion that FFD, alongside the related ‘Twin Distinction’ between natural and non-natural objects of aesthetic appreciation, dissolves. No such distinction can justify different treatment of natural and non-natural objects of aesthetic appreciation.

§1. ‘Framelessness’ in Environmental Aesthetics

In this section I will discuss the various uses of ‘frameless’ and ‘framed’ in aesthetics. I will briefly highlight what I do *not* mean by ‘framelessness’. When I refer to something as ‘frameless’, I do *not* mean that it has not been intentionally framed by some agent, nor do I mean that it inspires a certain *feeling* (of awe, wonder, vastness, sublimity, etc.), nor do I mean that the subject (the aesthetic appreciator, judge, experiencer, etc.) is

contained within that which they aesthetically appreciate.¹ Rather, for the purposes of this essay—in line with the employment of ‘framelessness’ in environmental aesthetics—I understand FFD as follows:²

- **Object of Aesthetic Experience (OAA, henceforth):** Anything that one might aesthetically appreciate (or judge, experience, etc.).³
- **Frame:** An OAA (x) has a ‘frame’ iff there is some ‘line’ or ‘divider’ (in the broadest sense) between that which the appreciator considers x, and that which the appreciator considers not-x.⁴
- **Framed:** An OAA is ‘framed’ iff it has a frame.
- **Frameless:** An OAA is ‘frameless’ iff it has no frame.

Typically, ‘framelessness’ is associated with that which is natural that we aesthetically appreciate (N-OAAs henceforth), and ‘framedness’ is associated with OAAs that are non-natural (Typically, art. As such, A-OAAs henceforth).⁵ This link between FFD and the A-OAA/N-OAA distinction—referred to as ‘*the Twin Distinction*’ henceforth—is especially apparent in the work of Hepburn and Carlson.⁶ Typically, the Twin Distinction is used to justify differing approaches to N-OAAs and A-OAAs.

In isolation, it might seem as though I define some arbitrary concept (‘framelessness’) whose failure is a simple analytic truth. This would of course be an entirely pointless endeavor. Rather, this concept—indeed, all the definitions in this section—are not manufactured for the purposes of this essay, but are intended to accurately reflect the notion of ‘framelessness’ that can be found at various points throughout the referenced works. Hepburn’s case for framelessness rests on the observation that natural

¹ Indeed, all of these concepts are closely related to ‘framelessness’. Unfortunately, this occasionally leads to these concepts messily overlapping with the use of the term ‘framelessness’. See (Campbell 1995, pp.8–19; Carlson 1995, p.393; Hopkins 1998; Currie in Levinson 2003, p.712; Hepburn in Cooper 2019, p.322)

² This is the received view of ‘framelessness’, as in: Budd 2002, p.110; Brady 2012, pp.93–96; Hepburn 2019, p.21; Matthews 2001, pp.395–401; Dickie 1974, pp.169, 173–174, 199–200; Carroll in Kemal and Gaskell 1993, p.251; Moore 2006, pp.1–2; Scruton 2011, p.91; Hepburn in Cooper 2019, pp.323–327; Budd in Levinson 2003, p.119

³ Here ‘object’ is used in the grammatical (not ontological) sense.

⁴ This ‘broadest sense’ of ‘line’ includes, for example, the ‘line’ between: the first and second acts of a play; confident and arrogant; a C-note and a D-note; etc.

⁵ For clarity, ‘non-natural’ is essentially that which is intentionally created by a human, and ‘natural’ is all else. Though, this is not overly relevant to my claims.

⁶ Hepburn in Cooper 2019, pp.322–324; Carlson 1979, pp.99–117

appreciation uniquely allows the appreciator to be ‘inside’ rather than ‘before’ its object—absorbed into a storm rather than positioned before a canvas. (Hepburn in Cooper 2019, pp.322–324) Carlson extends this, arguing that because natural objects lack the intentional structure of artworks, they provide no internal cues for determining what is and is not aesthetically relevant. (Carlson 1979, pp.99–117) On both accounts, the absence of a frame is not merely a physical feature but a condition of a distinctively open-ended mode of aesthetic engagement. I will argue throughout the remainder of this essay that there is no correlation between this concept of ‘framelessness’ and nature, and further that FFD dissolves completely.

§2. The Inapplicability of ‘Framelessness’

One cannot hope to argue for a one-to-one identity between ‘framelessness’ and N-OAAs (or ‘framedness’ and A-OAAs); it is apparent that a stone is just as framed as a sculpture. Indeed, the most popular and defensible notion of the Twin Distinction is rather one wherein ‘framelessness’ and ‘framedness’ are *broadly* correlated with N-OAAs and A-OAAs respectively. However, even this version of the Twin Distinction fails, as demonstrated below.

If one aesthetically appreciates something—that is, if one’s aesthetic appreciation is directed towards some OAA, rather than a non-directed, mystical *feeling* of appreciation—then one is singling out something (x) that is distinct from all else (not-x). If one singles out some x, as distinct from not-x, then she acknowledges a ‘line’ around x (and around not-x). That is, if the subject were to repeatedly ask ‘Is this x?’ and then change what ‘*this*’ refers to slightly (be that by a small spatial movement, by waiting a short period of time, etc.), they would eventually reach some ‘line’ on one side of which they would answer in the affirmative, and on the other side of which they would answer in the negative. Therefore, if x is an OAA then x is framed.

This is my main contention in this paper. Further, it seems we ought not say in aesthetics that ‘nothing is frameless’ but rather we should abstain from labelling OAAs ‘frameless’ or ‘framed’ altogether. This is a broadly Wittgensteinian point: aesthetic categories are governed by overlapping criteria and family resemblances, not by sharp necessary and sufficient conditions. The dissolution of ‘framelessness’ does not leave a void; it rather

clears the way for environmental aesthetics to identify any genuine differences between natural and non-natural aesthetic appreciation without relying on an incoherent binary. Without FFD, the Twin Distinction cannot be maintained.

One might object that this sense of ‘frame’ is too weak; that marking any distinction between *x* and not-*x* is not sufficient for the frame that environmental aestheticians have in mind, which requires a perceptually salient boundary of the kind a canvas edge provides. However, this objection concedes too much. If no such boundary structures the appreciation, then there is no determinate object being appreciated—only an aesthetic feeling, which is not appreciation of any object in particular. Either the experience is directed at a determinate object—in which case there must be conditions of identity that individuate that object from everything else, and those conditions just are its frame—or it is a non-directed affective state with no particular object, in which case it is not aesthetic appreciation of something but mere aesthetic feeling. The objector cannot have it both ways: if the appreciation is genuine, its object is individuated; if the object is not individuated, the appreciation is not of anything. This conclusion overlaps in certain respects with Ronald Moore’s (2006) argument that framing is an inevitable aspect of aesthetic experience. However, the present paper diverges from Moore in an important respect. Where Moore recharacterises frames as variable and permeable—preserving the language of framing while softening its implications—this paper argues that ‘framelessness’ should be abandoned as an aesthetic concept altogether. The question is not whether frames are rigid or flexible, but whether any coherent notion of framelessness can apply to an object of aesthetic appreciation. The answer, it is argued here, is that it cannot.

§3. Against the Intuitive Appeal of ‘Framelessness’

No argument for the inapplicability of ‘framelessness’ can immediately remove the intuitive appeal of FFD. As such, I will now analyse some common examples that give rise to FFD’s intuitive appeal.⁷ A-OAAs are uncontroversially characterised as framed. As such, I will focus on examples of supposedly ‘framelessness’ N-OAAs. To appeal to the use of FFD, one might say ‘a raging storm, which moves through space and waxes and wanes, is wild, untamed and *frameless*’. One may use such language when writing a

⁷ Such examples can be found thus: Berleant in Kemal and Gaskell 1993, p.237; Kant 2000, §26; Budd 2002, p.74; Levinson 2003, p.672; Scruton 2011, p.92; Brady 2012, p.101; Cooper [ed.] 2019, pp.110, 136

poem or a play, but we cannot take this to be *literally* true. We can (and very often do) differentiate between where and when a storm is and is not, and thus frame it. For example, I draw a ‘line’ around Storm Éowyn (SÉ) thusly: SÉ covered Dublin, January 24th; SÉ covered Scotland (and not Dublin) January 25th; at no point did SÉ cover Brazil; and so on.

In Figure 1, (a vastly simplified model of) SÉ is represented. This depiction of SÉ as spanning throughout time clarifies how we frame (and thus aesthetically appreciate) SÉ.⁸

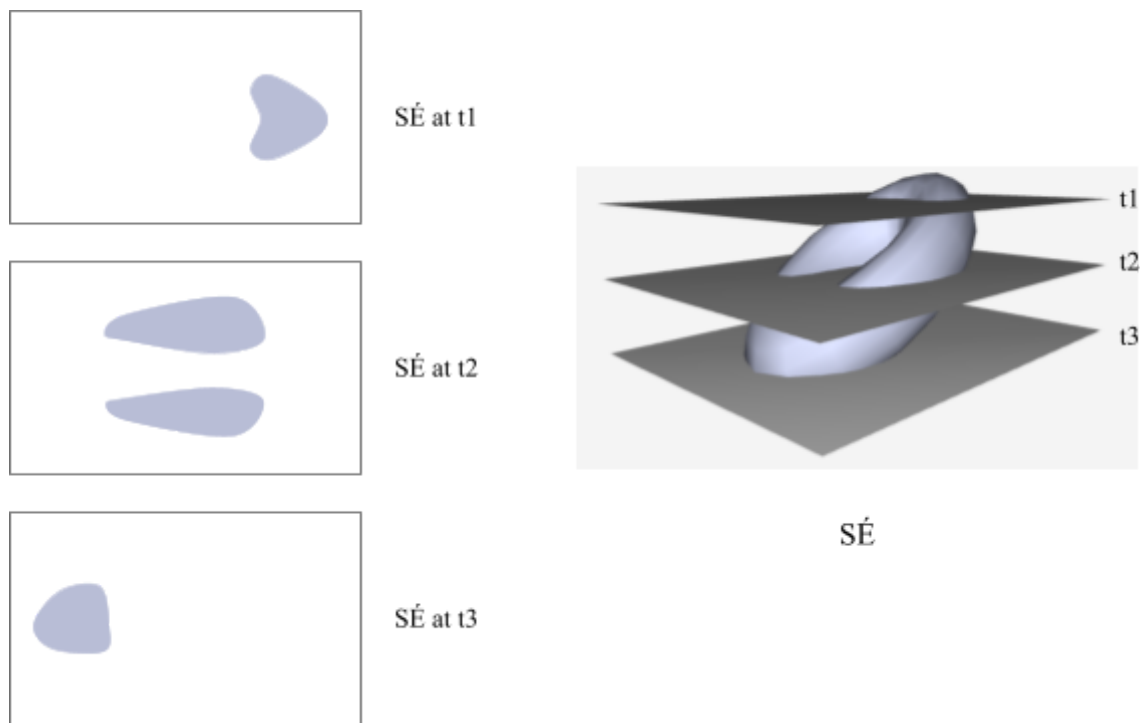


Figure 1. Storm Éowyn Through Time.

However, one’s ‘framelessness’ intuitions may persist, as there might be disagreement on where (or when) exactly SÉ ends and not-SÉ begins (which might be a less common feature of A-OAAs). However, this issue (concerning vagueness) is unproblematic. If SÉ is a distinct object in the world that has a boundary that exists independent from the subject, then these boundaries act as frames. Alternatively, if the world is divided up only by our imagination/ attention/ concepts/ etc. then this too allows for SÉ to be framed; the OAA is framed by the appreciator. When you and I discuss SÉ we may be talking about slightly different things; but each of us is certainly talking about something in particular.

⁸ This diagram assumes a framework wherein SÉ spans through time. However, no particular theory of time is required for this view; other popular notions of time (e.g. presentism) can draw the same conclusions (with slightly different diagrams).

In a given language, two speakers can use the same name to denote different objects (e.g. P1 and P2 can have a discussion about ‘that cloud’, even if P1 means C_1 by ‘that cloud’ and P2 means C_2 by ‘that cloud’).

The vagueness of SÉ’s boundary does not dissolve its frame; it merely makes the frame indeterminate, or subjective. A vague boundary is still a boundary: even if there is no precise moment at which SÉ ceases and the calm begins, there are clearly moments when SÉ is present and moments when it is not. The appreciator who engages with SÉ engages with a determinate (if vaguely bounded) region of meteorological history, not with an unbounded everything. Vagueness is a feature of many framed objects—including artworks, whose boundaries of meaning or relevance are often contested—and is no evidence of framelessness.

A more sophisticated objection, available from Carlson's own position, holds that the work ‘framelessness’ does is not about spatial or temporal boundaries at all, but about the absence of prescribed categories: natural objects, unlike artworks, provide no internal cues determining what properties are aesthetically relevant, and so the mode of engagement is open-ended in a way no framed artwork can be. (Carlson 1979, pp.99–117) However, this objection strengthens rather than undermines the present argument. If no categories are prescribed, then whatever categories the appreciator brings supply the frame—the indeterminacy is not in the object but in which frame is operative. Framelessness, even on this reading, remains inapplicable: appreciation is always conducted under some category, however subject-dependent, and that category constitutes the boundary between what is and is not aesthetically relevant.



Figure 2. The Vague Reference of ‘That Cloud’.

Sometimes this leads to trouble. For example, you and I could seemingly disagree about the factual matter of whether or not Michael Collins has been to the moon; a disagreement stemming from your referring to the former astronaut, and my referring to

the former minister for home affairs. However, often two people referring to different things by the same name goes unnoticed in conversation because the objects that the speakers are concerned with overlap so heavily that we scarcely ever notice that we are not talking about *exactly* the same thing (as in P1 and P2's discussion of 'that cloud' in Figure 2). Thus, on either conception of boundaries, OAAs remain necessarily framed.

The method applied above to clarify the example of SÉ can be adapted to address other common examples. Consider a 'landscape' which is thought to be 'frameless' because anything one experiences while appreciating the landscape becomes a part of it. We frame the landscape by excluding that which we do *not* experience. For example, if I am aesthetically appreciating the landscape at Silver Strand Beach, I am notably *not* appreciating any part of the Amazon Rainforest; and thus, at some point between where I am standing and the centre of the Amazon Rainforest there is a 'line' across which I would no longer affirm is part of Silver Strand Beach. This same method can apply to other common examples, such as the night-sky, vast oceans, deep ravines, sprawling mountains, etc. When appreciating any OAA (x), one draws a 'line' between x and not-x, simply by acknowledging that they are distinct. If one consistently denies this 'line' and does not distinguish between x and not-x, then it would seem that they are not claiming to appreciate some limited x (such as Silver Strand Beach) at all, but rather to be appreciating 'nature-as-a-whole' or 'everything'.

§4. Is Nature-as-a-whole 'Frameless'?

There is a further intuition that nature-as-a-whole is a special case; an especially likely candidate for 'framelessness'. If we consider nature-as-a-whole to be exclusive of (opposed to) non-nature-as-a-whole (perhaps, art-as-a-whole), then it is framed in just the same way as any other OAA. However, if we consider nature-as-a-whole to mean everything that we might appreciate, then one might consider it to potentially regain some notion of 'framelessness'. If nature-as-a-whole is an example of something which we might aesthetically appreciate that is indeed frameless, this would be problematic for my dissolution of FFD. There are two distinct possible characterisations of nature-as-a-whole: Nature-as-a-whole is finite, limited, and thus one can draw a 'line' around it; or, nature-as-a-whole is infinite and unlimited, one cannot draw a 'line' around it. The former case is patently unproblematic for my argument. The latter case seems more worrying. In order to clarify the example of infinite-nature-as-a-whole, I offer the

following analogy: If a statue is buried up to its neck with only its head above ground, and we (appreciators) can never have any way of knowing about or experiencing the body that lies beneath, we cannot appreciate the statue-as-a-whole, but only the statue-as-a-whole's head, for that is all we can access. Analogously, if nature-as-a-whole is unlimited and spans an infinite distance in every direction for eternity, then one can never experience or appreciate it in its entirety. As such, one cannot aesthetically appreciate it.

If one takes themselves to be aesthetically appreciating nature-as-a-whole, and therefore appreciating the 'framelessness' of some OAA, they are mislabelling that which they appreciate; they are appreciating some framed subset of nature-as-a-whole—perhaps 'all that which I have or ever will experience', or 'observable-nature-as-a-whole'—that they are mislabelling 'nature-as-a-whole'. Notably, all these mislabelled subsets are indeed framed for the reasons previously mentioned. One might resist this by claiming that infinite nature-as-a-whole can be appreciated under the concept 'everything', without requiring experiential access to each part—appreciating it as a totality rather than by traversing it. But to appreciate something under a concept is still to have a determinate intentional object: the concept itself has identity conditions, and hence a frame. As such, either nature-as-a-whole is indeed framed, or it is not aesthetically appreciable. In this case, we still cannot apply the notion of 'framelessness' to any OAA at all, and insofar as something has some metaphysical possibility to be infinite, unbound, all-encompassing, etc. this thing cannot be an OAA (indeed, it is questionable in what sense this thing would be a 'thing' at all, or how we might be able to speak of it).

One might press further, appealing to the Kantian sublime: perhaps what is being appreciated when one confronts infinite nature-as-a-whole is precisely the experience of that which exceeds all possible framing; the mind's encounter with what surpasses its grasp. (Kant 2000, §26) However, this does not rescue framelessness. The sublime experience is itself determinate: it is an experience of cognitive overwhelm, of one's own finitude confronted with the thought of the unlimited. That experience—and the thought it involves—is a framed object of appreciation. What the sublime appreciator appreciates is not infinite nature itself but a specific, bounded encounter with the idea of it. The gesture toward the unlimited is made from within a frame, not from outside all frames. The infinite remains beyond aesthetic appreciation; the framed experience of confronting it does not.

Conclusion

In conclusion, FFD—as conceived in the work of Hepburn, Carlson, and environmental aestheticians more broadly—dissolves due to the inapplicability of ‘framelessness’ to any OAA. Thus, one cannot use ‘framelessness’ to justify the need for separate approaches to N-OAAs and A-OAAs in aesthetics.

The seemingly intuitive examples in support of FFD can be reframed in light of this: storms, landscapes, and even nature-as-a-whole are either framed after all, or they are not objects of aesthetic appreciation at all. The dissolution of FFD has consequences beyond aesthetic theory: arguments in environmental ethics that appeal to nature’s boundlessness as grounds for moral consideration require re-examination, and methodological positions—such as Carlson’s natural environment model—that rely on FFD for their motivation are correspondingly weakened. If environmental aesthetics is to justify treating natural and non-natural objects differently, it must find other grounds than framelessness. The dissolution of FFD is a clarification: the genuine differences between our aesthetic appreciation of a storm and that of a symphony—if there are any—must be located in what those objects actually are, not in a fictional absence of boundaries. That is a more tractable, more honest, and more unifying starting point for any account of aesthetic experience.

Bibliography

- Brady, Emily. 2012. "Reassessing Aesthetic Appreciation of Nature in the Kantian Sublime." *Journal of Aesthetic Education* 46 (1): 91–109. <https://doi.org/10.5406/jaesteduc.46.1.0091>.
- Budd, Malcolm. 2002. *The Aesthetic Appreciation of Nature: Essays on the Aesthetics of Nature*. Clarendon press.
- Campbell, John. 1995. *Past, Space, and Self*. 1. paperback. ed. Representation and Mind. MIT Press.
- Carlson, Allen. 1979. "Formal Qualities in the Natural Environment." *Journal of Aesthetic Education* 13 (3): 99. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3331996>.
- Carlson, Allen. 1995. "Nature, Aesthetic Appreciation, and Knowledge." *The Journal of Aesthetics and Art Criticism* 53 (4): 393. <https://doi.org/10.2307/430974>.
- Cooper, David E., ed. 2019. *Aesthetics: The Classic Readings*. Second edition. Wiley Blackwell.
- Dickie, George. 1974. *Art and the aesthetic: an institutional analysis*. Cornell university press.
- Hepburn, Ronald William. 2019. *The Reach of the Aesthetic: Collected Essays on Art and Nature*. Routledge Revivals. Routledge.
- Hopkins, Robert. 1998. *Picture, Image and Experience: A Philosophical Inquiry*. Cambridge university press.
- Kant, Immanuel, and Paul Guyer, eds. 2000. *Critique of the Power of Judgment*. The Cambridge Edition of the Works of Immanuel Kant. Cambridge University Press.
- Kemal, Salim, and Ivan Gaskell. 1993. *Landscape, Natural Beauty and the Arts*. Cambridge Studies in Philosophy and the Arts. Cambridge university press.
- Levinson, Jerrold, ed. 2003. *The Oxford Handbook of Aesthetics*. Oxford University Press.
- Matthews, Patricia M. 2001. "Aesthetic Appreciation of Art and Nature." *British Journal of Aesthetics* 41 (4): 395–410. <https://doi.org/10.1093/bjaesthetics/41.4.395>.
- Moore, Ronald. 2006. "The Framing Paradox." *Ethics, Place & Environment* 9 (3): 249–67. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13668790600893301>.
- Scruton, Roger. 2011. *Beauty: A Very Short Introduction*. Very Short Introductions. Oxford Univ. Press. <https://doi.org/10.1093/actrade/9780199229758.001.0001>.